

UK Higher Education Levels, Awards, and Regulatory Oversight for Transnational Delivery with Sri Lankan Partners

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Abstract

This review synthesises the qualification frameworks, award structures, and regulatory expectations that shape UK higher education delivery, with specific application to transnational education (TNE) in Sri Lanka. It analyses the alignment between the Frameworks for Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ) and the Scottish Credit and Qualifications Framework (SCQF), outlines typical credit volumes and exit-award pathways, and summarises the governance arrangements across England, Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland. The review also examines the role of UK ENIC in supporting recognition and admissions, including advanced standing and comparability decisions. Using a structured evidence protocol with documented screening, extraction, and second-reader checks, the synthesis provides a replicable basis for understanding how provider accountability, quality assurance, student-protection duties, and reportable-events requirements apply in UK–Sri Lanka TNE provision. The findings offer a practical, standards-focused reference point for designing, delivering, and assuring academically credible and regulatorily compliant programmes that remain transparent and intelligible to students, partners, and regulators.

Keywords: UK Higher Education; FHEQ; SCQF; Transnational Education; UK ENIC; OfS Regulation; Quality Assurance; Sri Lanka Qualifications Framework; Exit Awards; Academic Standards; Partnership Governance; TNE Compliance.

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1 Introduction

Transnational education (TNE) continues to expand across the UK higher education sector, with partnerships, validation, franchise delivery, and distance-learning arrangements forming a significant component of the international footprint of UK degree-awarding bodies. As provision grows in scale and complexity, the need for clear alignment between qualification levels, award structures, regulatory expectations, and partner-delivery responsibilities becomes increasingly important. Ensuring that programmes delivered in Sri Lanka under UK awarding arrangements remain compliant, transparent, and intelligible to students, regulators, and employers requires an evidence-based synthesis of frameworks, standards, and oversight models across the UK home nations.

The UK qualifications architecture is defined primarily by the Frameworks for Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ) in England, Wales and Northern Ireland, and by the Scottish Credit and Qualifications Framework (SCQF) in Scotland. These frameworks set out level descriptors, typical credit volumes, award types, learning outcomes, and progression expectations. In Sri Lanka, the Sri Lanka Qualifications Framework (SLQF) provides the national reference point for qualification levels and credit norms, informing local recognition and programme evaluation.

At the regulatory level, England operates a registration-based system under the Office for Students (OfS), with conditions of registration that govern access and participation, quality and standards, financial sustainability, consumer protection, transparency, and information duties. Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland maintain distinct but related oversight models through the Scottish Funding Council (SFC), the Commission for Tertiary Education and Research (CTER), and the Department for the Economy (DfE NI), respectively. UK ENIC (ECCTIS) provides authoritative recognition advice for admissions, comparability, and credit transfer.

For UK providers delivering through Sri Lankan partners, it is essential that programme design aligns with FHEQ level descriptors, sector-recognised standards, and the expectations of UK regulators. This includes proportionate oversight of teaching, assessment, student outcomes, resources, support, student protection arrangements, and reportable events handling. Exit awards, progression routes, and credit volumes must be transparent and consistent to support recognition both locally and internationally.

This review synthesises the evidence base across levels, awards, governance, recognition, and TNE oversight to provide a coherent foundation for designing and assuring UK–Sri Lanka TNE provision. The outputs support the implementation of academically credible, regulatorily compliant, and student-centred programmes that remain intelligible to students, regulators, and employers.

2 Methods (Search and Selection)

Protocol adherence. All screening, selection, extraction, and second-reader verification procedures followed a predefined protocol (Version 0.2), finalised prior to data collection. The protocol specifies the source universe, eligibility criteria, search strategy, DocID conventions, evidence-capture rules, and second-reader sampling plan. The full protocol is reproduced in Appendix B and archived with the repository artefacts.

2.1 Sources

Two categories of sources informed the evidence base for this review:

- **Fixed UK sources:** Office for Students (OfS); Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education (QAA); Department for Education (DfE); UK ENIC (ECCTIS); Universities UK (UUK); SCQF Partnership; Scottish Funding Council (SFC); Welsh Government / CTER; Department for the Economy Northern Ireland (DfE NI); Ofqual.

- **Context sources (Sri Lanka):** Sri Lanka Qualifications Framework (SLQF) / University Grants Commission (UGC); British Council Sri Lanka.

All sources correspond to entries in `screening_log__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv` (12 items).

2.2 Date Window

The search prioritised current versions in force as of 2025, with backwards lineage consulted to approximately 2008 where required to understand regulatory transitions or framework evolution.

2.3 Search Queries

Searches used eight predefined query groups executed verbatim on Google and source-domain search bars:

- G1) `|site:qaa.ac.uk ("FHEQ" OR "qualification descriptors" OR "levels")|`
- G2) `|site:officeforstudents.org.uk (regulatory OR "conditions of registration" OR "validation" OR "franchise" OR "transnational education")|`
- G3) `|site:ecctis.com (recognition OR comparability OR "GCE A/L" OR "Sri Lanka")|`
- G4) `|site:gov.uk ("Quality Code" OR "sector-agreed principles" OR "higher education regulation")|`
- G5) `|site:scqf.org.uk (SCQF OR "level descriptors" OR "credit")|`
- G6) `|site:universitiesuk.ac.uk ("transnational education" OR TNE OR "quality assurance")|`
- G7) `|("exit award" OR "intermediate award" OR CertHE OR DipHE OR "graduate diploma" OR "postgraduate diploma") site:.ac.uk filetype:pdf|`
- G8) `|("validation" OR "franchise") ("partner" OR "delivery") ("quality assurance" OR "oversight") site:.ac.uk|`

2.4 Inclusion Criteria

In line with Protocol v0.2, items were included where they met one or more of the following:

- Official frameworks, award descriptors, and qualification statements.
- Regulatory frameworks, conditions, sector-recognised principles.
- University or awarding-body regulations for validation, franchise, or TNE.
- Official guidance/handbooks for partnerships and external quality assurance.
- Authoritative sector reports and peer-reviewed analyses relevant to TNE or recognition.

2.5 Exclusion Criteria

Items were excluded if they met any of the following:

- Marketing, opinion, consultancy, or agency content.
- Non-UK or non-higher education materials.
- Superseded sources lacking lineage value.
- General consumer information without regulatory or standards relevance.
- Items with no identifiable year, authoritativeness, or provenance.

2.6 Screening Process

Screening followed a defined workflow:

- Each record was logged in `screening_log__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv` under a DocID of the form `SRC-YY-###`.
- Items were assigned a status: Include / Exclude / Borderline.
- ReasonCodes were applied per dictionary: I1–I4 (Inclusion), E1–E4 (Exclusion), B1 (Borderline).
- Where licensing permitted, PDFs or web-prints of included items were downloaded locally for analysis. For copyright reasons, the public artefact bundle includes only the metadata in `evidence_manifest__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv`, not the PDFs themselves.
- Second-reader sampling covered: random ~15% of all screened items, all Borderline items, and all Excluded items.
- Disagreements were resolved by discussion; escalated cases were recorded in `agreement_summary__v0.1_2025-11-24.csv`.

2.7 Data Extraction

Data extraction used the template in `evidence_table__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv`, with the following fields:

- DocID; Title; Year; Jurisdiction; DocType; PrimaryFocus;
- KeyProvisions/Descriptors; Levels/Credits; ExitAwards;
- TNE/PartnerRules; Recognition/Entry (ENIC);
- Citations; UseInReview.

2.8 Risk and Limitations

- Search-process limitations were documented in real time and include the behaviours described below.
- Risks included regulatory updates between capture and analysis, site restructuring, PDFs without pagination, and sector reports that describe practice rather than prescribe requirements.

- A small number of predefined queries (G3, G4 and G7) returned atypical results (e.g., image-only outputs or no indexed hits). These outcomes were retained verbatim for transparency, consistent with PRISMA expectations. As recommended in the protocol, no post hoc modification of queries was undertaken; results were recorded as returned, with additional checks made via internal domain search bars where applicable.

2.9 Deviations From Protocol

None.

3 Results — Levels and Awards

3.1 Levels and Alignment

FHEQ structures higher education levels from 4 to 8 with typical award titles at each stage: CertHE (Level 4), DipHE or Foundation Degree (Level 5), Bachelor’s degrees (Ordinary/Honours) (Level 6), Master’s degrees (Level 7), and Doctoral degrees (Level 8). Typical undergraduate volume is approximately 120 credits per level, yielding around 360 credits for an Honours bachelor’s degree by Level 6. Taught master’s degrees normally require 180 credits. Doctoral degrees are not usually credit-rated, although credit-bearing professional doctorates commonly allocate around 540 credits.

Scotland aligns these levels through the SCQF: FHEQ Level 4 ↔ SCQF 7; Level 5 ↔ 8; Level 6 ↔ 9/10; Level 7 ↔ 11; and Level 8 ↔ 12, supporting recognition, mobility, and progression across the UK.

(QAA-24-001; SCQF-25-001)

3.2 Levels Map (FHEQ–SCQF)

Note. Because the full table exceeds standard page width under the article class, each level is presented in a structured `tcOLORBOX` entry. This approach preserves clarity, prevents overfull lines, and ensures compatibility with repository rendering (e.g., arXiv, Zenodo).

Level 4

FHEQ Level: Level 4
SCQF Level: 7
Typical Awards: CertHE (EWNI); HNC (Scotland)
Exit Awards: CertHE
Credits: ~120 credits at Level 4
Key Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 4 descriptor), SCQF Interactive Framework.

Level 5

FHEQ Level: Level 5
SCQF Level: 8
Typical Awards: DipHE; Foundation Degree (FdA/FdSc); HND (Scotland)
Exit Awards: DipHE; Foundation Degree
Credits: ~240 by end of Level 5
Key Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 5 descriptor), SCQF Interactive Framework.

Level 6

FHEQ Level: Level 6

SCQF Level: 9/10

Typical Awards: Bachelor's (Hons); Bachelor's (Ordinary)

Exit Awards: Graduate Certificate; Graduate Diploma

Credits: Ordinary ~300; Honours ~360

Key Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 6 descriptor), SCQF Interactive Framework.

Level 7

FHEQ Level: Level 7

SCQF Level: 11

Typical Awards: Master's (MA/MSc); Integrated Master's (MEng/MChem)

Exit Awards: PGCert; PGDip

Credits: Master's 180; PGCert 60; PGDip 120; Integrated Master's ~480

Key Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 7 descriptor), SCQF Interactive Framework.

Level 8

FHEQ Level: Level 8

SCQF Level: 12

Typical Awards: Doctoral degrees (PhD/DPhil; Professional Doctorate)

Exit Awards: Not typical

Credits: Not credit-rated; professional doctorates ~540

Key Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 8 descriptor), SCQF Interactive Framework.

3.3 Exit-Award Pathways

Exit-award pathways provide recognised qualifications for students who do not complete the intended programme. At Level 4, the typical exit award is a CertHE; at Level 5, a DipHE or Foundation Degree; at Level 6, a Graduate Certificate or Graduate Diploma (alongside the Ordinary bachelor's degree where used); and at Level 7, postgraduate certificates or postgraduate diplomas may be awarded (typically PGCert 60 credits, PGDip 120 credits). These awards reflect the credit-volume and level-descriptor structure of the FHEQ.

(QAA-24-001)

3.4 Exit Awards Map

Level 4

Context: First year of bachelor's or standalone

Primary Award: CertHE

Exit Awards: None typical below Level 4

Credits: ~120

Progression: To Level 5

Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 4 descriptor).

Level 5

Context: Second year of bachelor's; DipHE/Foundation Degree

Primary Award: DipHE / Foundation Degree

Exit Awards: CertHE

Credits: ~240

Progression: To Level 6

Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 5 descriptor).

Level 6

Context: Final year of bachelor's (Ordinary/Honours)

Primary Award: Bachelor's degree

Exit Awards: CertHE; DipHE; Graduate Certificate / Graduate Diploma

Credits: ~360 (Honours)

Progression: To Level 7 (subject to entry criteria)

Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 6 descriptor).

Level 7

Context: Taught master's; integrated master's stage

Primary Award: Master's degree

Exit Awards: PGCert; PGDip

Credits: Master's 180; Integrated Master's 480

Progression: To doctoral study

Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 7 descriptor).

Level 8

Context: Doctoral study (PhD/DPhil; professional doctorates)

Primary Award: Doctoral degree

Exit Awards: Not typical

Credits: Not credit-rated; professional doctorates ~540

Progression: Research and academic routes

Citation: FHEQ 2024 (Level 8 descriptor).

4 Results — Governance and Oversight

4.1 England (Office for Students and Governance System)

England's regulator, the Office for Students (OfS), operates a registration-based framework under the Higher Education and Research Act (HERA). Providers registered with the OfS must comply with Conditions of Registration A–G, which cover access and participation, quality and standards, financial sustainability, transparency, information requirements, and student protection arrangements.

The registered (lead) provider remains responsible for quality and standards wherever provision is delivered, including validated, franchised, subcontracted, or transnational education (TNE) arrangements. Sanctions for non-compliance range from specific conditions to suspension or deregistration. As an arm's-length body sponsored by the Department for Education (DfE), the

OfS is governed by a framework document that outlines its strategic functions, accountability routes, and regulatory powers.

Jurisdiction: England
Regulator: Office for Students (OfS)
Model: Registration system (Conditions A–G)
Partnership Responsibility: Lead provider fully accountable
Student Protection: Student Protection Plans (SPP); consumer compliance
Sanctions: Targeted conditions; fines; suspension; deregistration
Key DocIDs: OFS-22-001; DFE-23-001

4.2 Devolved Nations (Scotland, Wales, Northern Ireland)

Oversight in the devolved nations differs structurally but retains alignment with UK-wide expectations for academic standards.

Scotland (Scottish Funding Council)

In Scotland, the Scottish Funding Council (SFC) operates an enhancement-led quality model for SFC-funded institutions. Rather than a registration system, SFC guidance specifies quality-enhancement principles, roles, annual evaluation mechanisms, and expectations for public information. Institutions remain responsible for assuring collaborative or partnership provision. SFC interventions are primarily linked to funding or support measures.

Jurisdiction: Scotland
Regulator/Body: Scottish Funding Council (SFC)
Model: Enhancement-led quality approach
Provider Register: No
Partnership Responsibility: Institutions assure collaborative provision
Student Interests: Student engagement; public information
Sanctions/Interventions: Funding conditions; support interventions
Key DocID: SFC-25-001

Wales (CTER / Welsh Government)

Wales operates under the Commission for Tertiary Education and Research (CTER), which sets policy for registration, designation for student support, and quality assessment frequency. Providers remain responsible for partnership delivery, and CTER may issue regulatory directions or amend funding conditions.

Jurisdiction: Wales
Regulator/Body: CTER / Welsh Government
Model: Registration and designation policy
Provider Register: Yes
Partnership Responsibility: Provider accountable
Quality Assessment: Frequency signalled by CTER
Sanctions/Interventions: Directions; variation/withdrawal of funding
Key DocID: WELSH-25-001

Northern Ireland (Department for the Economy)

Northern Ireland does not operate a dedicated registration system; oversight is provided through DfE NI policy frameworks linked to funding, accountability, transparency, and strategic objectives. Institutions remain responsible for the quality and standards of any collaborative provision under their awarding powers.

Jurisdiction: Northern Ireland

Regulator/Body: Department for the Economy (DfE NI)

Model: Policy and funding oversight

Provider Register: No

Partnership Responsibility: Institutions accountable for provision

Student Interests: Transparency and public information

Interventions: Funding or designation changes

Key DocID: NIDE-25-001

4.3 Synthesis Across UK Nations

Across the UK, governance varies in regulatory structure but remains aligned in protecting academic standards, student interests, and institutional accountability:

- England’s OfS model is the most prescriptive, using conditions of registration.
- Scotland emphasises enhancement and funding-linked quality arrangements.
- Wales integrates oversight into a unified tertiary framework via CTER.
- Northern Ireland sets expectations through policy, funding, and accountability routes.

Despite these differences, all nations rely on sector-recognised standards, programme-level academic regulations, and institutional responsibility for partnership delivery. This creates a coherent set of expectations for UK providers delivering transnationally, including in Sri Lanka.

5 Discussion

5.1 Implications for UK–Sri Lanka Transnational Delivery

For UK providers delivering programmes with Sri Lankan partners, alignment with the Frameworks for Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ) and, where relevant, SCQF equivalences is essential for maintaining academic coherence, transparent progression, and credible recognition. Programme structures should map explicitly to level descriptors, learning outcomes, and typical credit volumes, ensuring that students can understand how their programme fits within the wider UK qualifications system.

Under the Office for Students (OfS) regulatory framework, the registered lead provider retains full responsibility for academic standards and quality wherever provision is delivered. This includes validated, franchised, subcontracted, or distance-learning delivery in Sri Lanka. Therefore, local teaching and assessment must operate within the awarding provider’s academic regulations, quality cycle, and reporting structures. Student protection planning, consumer law compliance, data duties, and reportable-events handling remain obligations of the UK provider; Sri Lankan delivery partners must support these requirements operationally.

Recognition and admissions processes should draw on UK ENIC Statements of Comparability to ensure defensible decisions for both entry and advanced standing. This underpins transparency, equity, and consistency for Sri Lankan applicants, particularly where qualification mapping

between SLQF and FHEQ levels is required. Sector evidence from British Council Sri Lanka and Universities UK International highlights areas of opportunity and ongoing risk signals in local TNE delivery, informing due diligence, governance, and student-outcome monitoring frameworks.

Key implications for UK–Sri Lanka provision:

- Programme design should follow FHEQ level descriptors and UK credit norms.
- Exit-award pathways must be transparent and mapped to FHEQ and SLQF structures.
- The UK lead provider remains wholly accountable under OfS Conditions A–G.
- Admissions and advanced standing require UK ENIC-supported comparability.
- Local partners must support student protection, data, consumer, and reporting duties.
- TNE risk signals from British Council Sri Lanka and UUK should shape partnership oversight.

5.2 Limitations and Practical Constraints

Interpretation of regulatory expectations across the UK home nations is influenced by structural differences. Scotland’s enhancement-led quality model, governed through SFC guidance, is not directly equivalent to the OfS registration system. Wales, through the Commission for Tertiary Education and Research (CTER), integrates oversight into a single tertiary framework, including policy for registration, designation, and quality assessment. Northern Ireland’s Department for the Economy provides policy and funding oversight rather than a codified provider-registration framework. As a result, comparisons must be made carefully, acknowledging the different levers and regulatory instruments in each nation.

Further limitations include website restructuring between evidence capture and analysis, availability of PDFs without stable pagination, and the descriptive rather than prescriptive nature of many sector reports. These affect generalisability and require professional interpretation, especially when translating regulatory models to transnational delivery contexts.

Key limitations:

- Variation in regulatory structures across UK nations affects comparability.
- SFC, CTER, and DfE NI issue guidance that differs from OfS conditions in scope.
- Some evidence (e.g., TNE reports) is descriptive, not regulatory.
- Website changes and document availability may affect reproducibility.
- Local SLQF alignment requires careful judgement when interpreting UK standards.

6 Conclusion

This review brings together the principal frameworks, regulatory expectations, and recognition mechanisms shaping UK higher education delivery, with a particular focus on transnational education (TNE) involving Sri Lankan partners. It synthesises how qualification levels and award structures align across the FHEQ and SCQF, how oversight is organised differently across England, Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland, and how recognition and admissions processes intersect with UK ENIC comparability guidance.

For UK providers delivering through Sri Lankan partners, programme design and quality assurance must be explicitly mapped to FHEQ level descriptors and typical credit volumes, ensuring that progression routes and exit awards remain transparent and academically coherent. Under the Office for Students (OfS) regulatory framework, the registered lead provider retains full responsibility for quality and standards wherever learning is delivered; validated, franchised, and subcontracted delivery must therefore operate within the awarding body's regulations, monitoring cycle, student-protection arrangements, and reporting duties.

Admissions and advanced-standing decisions should rely on UK ENIC evidence to support clear, equitable, and defensible judgements, particularly where comparisons between SLQF and FHEQ levels are needed. Assurance priorities for Sri Lanka include robust partner due diligence, scheduled monitoring of academic delivery, external examining and assessment moderation, accurate and timely handling of reportable events, and credible teach-out planning.

Overall, the review provides a structured foundation for implementing academically credible, regulatorily compliant, and student-centred TNE provision that is intelligible to students, regulators, and employers. It also offers a reproducible evidence base to support ongoing governance, partnership oversight, and programme development in UK–Sri Lanka higher education collaborations.

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8 References (DocID–Linked)

The following references correspond to the DocIDs used throughout this review. Each entry provides the full citation and access date, consistent with the evidence records captured in `references__v0.1_2025-11-24.csv`.

QAA-24-001

Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education. *The Frameworks for Higher Education Qualifications of UK Degree-Awarding Bodies*. 2024. Available at: https://www.qaa.ac.uk/docs/qaa/quality-code/the-frameworks-for-higher-education-qualifications-of-uk-degree-awarding-bodies-2024.pdf?sfvrsn=3562b281_11. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

OfS-22-001

Office for Students. *Securing student success: Regulatory framework for higher education in England*. 2022. Available at: <https://www.officeforstudents.org.uk/media/qzqblugo/securing-student-success-regulatory-framework-for-higher-education-in-england-2022.pdf>. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

DFE-23-001

Department for Education. *Framework document between the Department for Education and the Office for Students*. 2023. Available at: https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/63c56f98e90e074eed258011/OfS_framework_document.pdf. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

ENIC-25-001

UK ENIC (ECCTIS). *Statement of Comparability*. 2025. Available at: <https://www.enic.org>.

uk/individuals/statement-of-comparability. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

UUK-25-001

Universities UK. *The scale of UK HE TNE 2021–22*. 2025. Available at: <https://www.universitiesuk.ac.uk/universities-uk-international/insights-and-publications/uuki-publications/scale-uk-he-tne-2021-22>. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

SCQF-25-001

SCQF Partnership. *Using the Framework (Interactive Framework)*. 2025. Available at: <https://scqf.org.uk/the-framework/interactive-framework/>. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

SFC-25-001

Scottish Funding Council. *SFC Guidance on Quality for Colleges and Universities AY 2024-25 to AY 2030-31: Refresh*. 2025. Available at: <https://www.sfc.ac.uk/wp-content/uploads/2025/06/SFC-Guidance-on-Quality-for-colleges-and-universities-AY2024-25-to-2030-31-refresh.pdf>. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

WELSH-25-001

Welsh Government. *Regulation of higher education providers and designation for student support*. 2025. Available at: <https://www.gov.wales/sites/default/files/pdf-versions/2025/4/2/1744102075/regulation-higher-education-providers-and-designation-student-support.pdf>. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

NIDE-25-001

Department for the Economy (Northern Ireland). *Higher Education*. 2025. Available at: <https://www.economy-ni.gov.uk/topics/higher-education>. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

OFQUAL-25-001

Office of Qualifications and Examinations Regulation (Ofqual). *General Conditions of Recognition*. 2025. Available at: <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/ofqual-handbook>. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

SLQF-23-001

University Grants Commission (Sri Lanka). *Manual for Certification of Level of Educational Qualifications in Accordance with the SLQF*. 2023. Available at: <https://med.pdn.ac.lk/admin/iqac/downloads/Programme%20Review%20Manuals/5.%20SLQF%20Certification%20Manual.pdf>. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

BCSL-24-001

British Council Sri Lanka. *Transnational Education in Sri Lanka: Operational and Quality Assurance Landscape*. 2024. Available at: https://www.britishcouncil.lk/sites/default/files/sri_lanka_tne_report_august_2024.pdf. Accessed: 2025-10-13.

A Repository Artefacts

This appendix lists the archived artefacts captured during the review process. Each file corresponds to a reproducible component of the screening, extraction, or agreement workflow and is preserved in the accompanying data repository.

A.1 Screening and Evidence Records

- screening_log__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv
- evidence_table__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv
- evidence_manifest__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv

A.2 Second-Reader Checks and Agreement

- `second_reader_screen_sample__v0.1_completed_2025-11-24.csv`
- `second_reader_extraction_sample__v0.1_completed_2025-11-24.csv`
- `agreement_summary__v0.1_2025-11-24.csv`

A.3 Codebook and References

- `reason_codes_dictionary__v0.1_2025-11-24.csv`
- `references__v0.1_2025-11-24.csv`

A.4 Notes on Reproducibility

All artefacts are included to support transparency, auditability, and reproducibility of the review. Filenames retain a freeze-date suffix to ensure traceability between versions of the evidence base. Each artefact aligns with the steps described in the Methods section and the protocol (Appendix B).

B Review Protocol v0.2

This appendix reproduces the protocol that governed all screening, extraction, quality assurance, and second-reader verification steps for this review. The protocol was finalised as Version 0.2 and followed without deviation. The original file (`protocol_v0.2.md`) is archived alongside other repository artefacts.

B.1 Purpose and Scope

This protocol defines the procedures for identifying, screening, extracting, and validating evidence relating to UK higher education frameworks, levels, awards, regulatory oversight, qualification comparability, and transnational education (TNE) delivery with Sri Lankan partners.

B.2 Source Categories

Two categories of sources were defined:

- **Fixed UK sources:** Office for Students (OfS); Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education (QAA); Department for Education (DfE); UK ENIC (ECCTIS); Universities UK; SCQF Partnership; Scottish Funding Council (SFC); Welsh Government / CTER; Department for the Economy Northern Ireland (DfE NI); Ofqual.
- **Context sources (Sri Lanka):** Sri Lanka Qualifications Framework (SLQF) / University Grants Commission (UGC); British Council Sri Lanka.

Note. Potential Sri Lankan sources identified during protocol development (MOHE, TVEC) yielded no eligible documents under the inclusion criteria and were therefore not included in the final evidence set.

Only official, authoritative, and versioned documents from these providers were eligible for inclusion.

B.3 Time Window

The review prioritised current versions in force as of 2025. Earlier versions were consulted for lineage or regulatory transition where required, generally back to approximately 2008.

B.4 Search Strategy

Eight predefined query groups (G1–G8) were executed verbatim on Google and on provider-domain search bars. Searches combined:

- site-restricted queries;
- award/credit/level terminology;
- regulatory terms (conditions, quality, validation, franchise, TNE);
- recognition/comparability terminology (ENIC, GCE A/L, Sri Lanka);
- exit-award and intermediate-award terms;
- partnership/oversight terms.

All queries were executed using identical syntax for reproducibility.

B.5 Inclusion Criteria

Items were included where they met one or more of the following:

- official frameworks, award descriptors, qualification statements;
- regulatory frameworks, conditions, sector-recognised principles;
- official guidance for validation, franchise, or TNE;
- university or awarding-body academic regulations (exit awards);
- authoritative sector reports or peer-reviewed analyses.

B.6 Exclusion Criteria

Items were excluded where they met one or more of the following:

- opinion/marketing/blog/agent materials;
- non-UK or non-HE materials;
- superseded versions without lineage relevance;
- general information without regulatory or standards substance;
- documents without year, authority, or identifiable provenance.

B.7 DocID Scheme

Each screened item was assigned a DocID of the form SRC-YY-### (where SRC is replaced by the source-provider prefix, e.g., QAA, OFS, SLQF, BCSL). This identifier linked the screening log, evidence table, PDF archive, and reference list.

B.8 Screening Process

Screening was logged in `screening_log__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv` with fields:

- DocID;
- Source;
- URL and capture details;
- Title;
- Publisher;
- Year;
- Country;
- DocType;
- Status (Include / Exclude / Borderline);
- ReasonCode (I1–I4, E1–E4, B1);
- Notes;

PDFs were saved under a consistent directory scheme. For example: `evidence/QAA/QAA-24-001__QAA__2024.pdf`. These files were logged in `evidence_manifest__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv`.

B.9 Second-Reader Sampling

A second reader independently reviewed:

- approximately 15% of included items,
- all Borderline items,
- all Excluded items.

Disagreements were resolved by discussion and summarised in `agreement_summary__v0.1_2025-11-24.csv`.

B.10 Data Extraction

Extraction followed the schema in `evidence_table__v0.1_freeze_2025-11-24.csv`, including:

- DocID, Title, Year, Jurisdiction, Document Type;
- Primary Focus;
- Key Provisions / Level Descriptors;
- Levels and Credits;
- Exit Awards;
- TNE or Partnership Rules;
- Recognition / Entry (ENIC);
- Citations and Use in Review.

B.11 Risk and Limitations

Risks included:

- regulatory updates during the review period;
- site restructures affecting URL access;
- unpaginated PDFs;
- sector reports that are descriptive rather than prescriptive.

B.12 Deviations

No deviations occurred during the review.

B.13 ReasonCode Dictionary

The following ReasonCodes were used during screening and second-reader verification to ensure consistency, reproducibility, and auditability across all decisions. Codes are grouped into Inclusion (I1–I4), Exclusion (E1–E4), and Borderline (B1).

Code	Definition
I1	Meets inclusion criteria: official framework, qualification descriptor, or award statement.
I2	Meets inclusion criteria: regulatory framework, condition, or sector-recognised principle.
I3	Meets inclusion criteria: official validation, franchise, or TNE guidance.
I4	Meets inclusion criteria: authoritative sector report or peer-reviewed analysis.
E1	Excluded: opinion, marketing, agent, promotional, or blog content.
E2	Excluded: non-UK or not higher-education-level material.
E3	Excluded: superseded or outdated version without lineage relevance.
E4	Excluded: insufficient authority, missing year, unverifiable provenance, or unclear source.
B1	Borderline relevance: requires additional judgement, context interpretation, or second-reader review.